

HEADING BACK TO THE WILD...



Toni O'Neil, a volunteer with the Carolina Raptor Center near Huntersville, holds a great horned owl and one of two released in the Marshville-Peachland woodlands Tuesday. The male owl had been injured Sept. 9 at a local gas station.

Great horned owls regain freedom after rehabilitation

By John Edmondson

Two great horned owls, once thought never to fly again, were released -- rested and repaired -- into 10 acres of woodlands near Marshville on Tuesday afternoon.

One of the birds, a male, was seriously injured on Sept. 9, when he crashed into the awning of the Servco station on U.S. Highway 74 in Marshville. Toni O'Neil, a volunteer with the Carolina Raptor Center, took the bird to the center where he underwent rehabilitation.

The other bird that was released was a female that had been illegally trapped near Asheville. The female had suffered leg injuries when found on Aug. 16 of this year. Both birds had been together since September, O'Neil said.

The Carolina Raptor Center, located in Huntersville north of Charlotte, helps to treat and rehabilitate injured and orphaned raptors, or birds of prey like owls, hawks, eagles, falcons and vultures. Its mission statement says the facility "is dedicated to environmental education and conservation of birds of prey through public education, rehabilitation of injured and orphaned raptors, and research."

Both birds released Tuesday about 4:30 p.m. have a good chance of survival, O'Neil said.

"They've had inside care and medicine, and their stitches have needed time for healing," she explained. "They have been in what we call a pre-release cage, and have had practice flights."

The birds have also had real feathers from similar birds glued in place of feathers they were missing. Those feathers impeded, as they are called, will work for flying and balance until the birds molt next year, O'Neil said.

The great horned owl injured at the Servco station in Marshville had



A female great horned owl heads for the trees Tuesday after she was released near Marshville by Toni O'Neil, a Carolina Raptor Center volunteer. Each year, 40-70 injured or dying great horned owls are turned in to the Raptor Center.

three joints dislocated. His left wing was slightly drooped as he sat on O'Neil's gloved hand Tuesday afternoon. "He will have this drop in his wing when he perches, but it will enable him to fly and survive," she added. Such owls have a wingspan of 35-55 inches and grow to 25 inches high.

Great horned owls are highly adaptable and reside in woodlands, cliffs, suburban estates, parks and cemeteries. They range from sea level to about 11,000 feet, Raptor Center experts say.

These owls eat mainly mice, rabbits, rats, but will also feast on opossums, squirrels, gophers and meadow mice. They are known to kill cats, skunks and even, although not commonly, large birds like ducks, turkeys and chickens. The great horned owls kill large numbers of crows by strafing their roosts at night.

The Carolina Raptor Center can be reached by calling 704-875-6521. That is also the number to call if you find an injured or baby raptor. It is located at 600 Sample Road off Interstate 77. It is open to the public.